



MONTHLY UPDATE

Malawi: monthly update, August – September 2026

Edition of 2026-09-01 • 30 systems and instruments tracked

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH • GOVERNANCE • ICT INFRASTRUCTURE • DPI • DIGITALISATION • CAPACITY • INCLUSION
• DATA

Summary of the month

Two systems went the wrong way and one was made more resilient. The farm input subsidy programme [reverted to manual coupons for 2026-27](#), a return [technologists questioned before the September rollout](#) “this ledger's clearest case of a digitised process being undone” and the state oil company [confirmed the loss of K700m to payment fraud](#). Against them, the revenue authority's [secondary data centre is reported improving service continuity at border posts and the international airport](#).

The measurements were the month's more useful half. An industry association [put 80% of the population offline against 87% 4G population coverage](#) “a usage gap rather than a coverage one” while the statistics office and the regulator [opened enumerator training for a fourth national ICT survey covering 12,000 households](#). Parliament [passed the Financial Crimes \(Amendment\) Bill](#), which awaits assent, and the minister [stated an intention to legislate on artificial intelligence](#).

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The draft national artificial intelligence strategy the UNESCO readiness assessment is intended to guide remains pre-adoption.

The revenue authority launched a five-year Corporate Strategic Plan in Blantyre on 24 August, [resting on a wider tax base, digitisation and evidence-based research and targeting a rise in the tax-to-GDP ratio from 16 per cent towards 20 per cent by 2031](#), the finance minister framing domestic taxation as the route left by falling donor support and shrinking customs revenue.

Legislation and regulation

Two instruments, one passed and one only intended. Parliament [passed the Financial Crimes \(Amendment\) Bill in the week to 6 August](#), which awaits assent; the bill text is not held, so what it changes for digital finance cannot be read off the record. Separately the minister [stated an intention to legislate on artificial intelligence](#), with no draft, scope or timetable behind the statement.

Regional collaboration

Regional work was two conversations. The minister [urged the regional bloc to target artificial-intelligence investment at a Lilongwe workshop](#), and a delegation [visited Accra to discuss digital-government cooperation with Ghana](#). Neither carries a memorandum, funding figure or timetable.

Standards

On 3 August the copyright society's blank media levy distribution was reported to rest on records submitted by licensed disc-burning centres rather than on digital consumption, with a proposal to key distribution to digital consumption voted down at an annual general meeting.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

The communications regulator found both mobile operators in breach of the tariff-notice requirement on 17 July 2026, for failing to publish approved tariff changes in at least two daily newspapers seven days before they took effect. Both agreed to credit customers who bought affected products between 26 June and 2 July with bundles equal to the price difference, and to submit evidence of compliance by 31 July ([regulator order](#)). The approved price increase itself stands.

The ICT minister told Parliament on 17 July that additional mobile operator licences are under consideration, and on 24 July that the President had authorised the ministry to identify an investor able to roll out a network without delay; no bid timetable, licence terms or spectrum allocation was stated. The minister also told the House that spectrum licence fees had been reduced by 50%, against the 20% the regulator announced in June 2025 ([parliamentary account](#)).

The gap the licensing round is meant to close acquired figures in August. An industry association report published ahead of its Malawi summit on 20 August [puts fourth-generation coverage at 87% of the population against mobile-internet penetration of 12.5%, with mobile-money adoption described as near universal, and scores Malawi 36 of 100 on its digital nations and society index and 55 of 100 on policy and regulation](#). These are the association's own index and figures; the base still holds no official national subscriber and coverage series.

The operator's annual report replaced a figure that had carried no period. It [puts network infrastructure investment at MK30.87bn in 2025, directed mainly at modernisation, 4G site expansion and continued 5G rollout; the US\\$31m the same operator stated in August](#) carried no period and is not reconciled with it.

Data Storage

The revenue authority's own resilience improved on donor money. Its [World Bank-funded secondary data centre and uninterruptible power supply upgrades are reported as improving service continuity, cutting queues and improving customs-duty accuracy at border posts and the international airport](#), under a six-year, US\$150m regional trade and connectivity project running to 2027. The financing commitment date is not stated in the record held, and no capacity, location or availability figure is given for the facility.

Cybersecurity

The month's cybersecurity item is a loss rather than a control. The state oil company [was defrauded of K700m after attackers hijacked email from its Mozambican fuel-handling contractor and supplied false banking details, instructing its bank on 29 April 2026 to wire US\\$403,605 to a fraudulent account](#); the fraud surfaced two weeks later when the genuine contractor demanded payment, and was confirmed publicly on 24 August 2026. The

company attributes the control weaknesses to the government-to-government fuel procurement model being introduced before operational and cybersecurity procedures were in place. No regulator finding, prosecution or recovery is on file.

DPI

Data Exchange

On 5 August the revenue authority signed an arrangement with its South African counterpart for real-time customs data exchange, with no go-live date and no published purpose-limitation, retention or reciprocity terms ([signing account](#)).

Two days later the South African side notified the update from its end, [publishing the arrangement for automatic exchange of customs information together with a draft rule amendment](#). The rule is still in draft and the go-live date is still unstated.

Digital Identity and CRVS

The registration bureau reported on 13 July 2026 that more than 13.5 million people hold a national digital identity, with over 150,000 enrolled between April and June, 53% of them women ([registration bureau](#)). On 6 July it named the forthcoming mobile credential and set its launch for September 2026 ([registration bureau](#)). On 5 August a separate blockchain-enabled wallet built by the United Nations Development Programme was stated to be in pilot ahead of nationwide rollout; neither announcement names the other.

Using the system got more expensive. The bureau [raised fees for national identity card replacement, electronic know-your-customer verification, civil registration and marriage services](#) under the National Registration (Amendment) Regulations 2026, gazetted on 31 July. The individual fee levels and their previous values are not carried in the record held, so the size of the increase is not established — but the charge for electronic know-your-customer verification is a charge on third parties for using the identity system, levied in the same month the bureau reported approaching universal coverage.

Digital Payments and Fintech

On 25 July the central bank's expected banknote replacement cost for 2026 was reported at MWK 69.8bn against MWK 50.6bn in 2025, with an economists' association president naming government levies on digital money transfers as a reason cash use persists.

Two things moved in the regional rails above it. The regional clearing house [published the scheme rulebook for instant low-cost cross-border retail payments, with a gender audit and strategy to 2030 drawn from research along the corridor with Zambia](#), which gives the platform operational and governance rules it did not have. Separately a commercial bank and an international card scheme [opened online acceptance of that scheme's cards to participating merchants in nine African markets including Malawi on 19 August](#), settling in local currency, US dollars or both; the merchant count is given for the nine markets together and not for Malawi.

The same report gives the mobile-money platform its first published revenue line: [MK51.93bn in 2025, up 77 per cent, on a stated base of more than 140,000 active agents](#).

Registries

The land register was reviewed rather than extended. A [workflow review workshop was convened on the Land Information Management System](#). Reviewing workflows is what is done when a system is in service and not working as intended; no parcel count, coverage figure or defect list is published.

Sectoral management information systems

Two internal systems are close to the point where they carry real work. The automated human resource and payroll management platform [is in pilot ahead of government-wide rollout](#), and the Labour Market Information System [reached the final stage before launch after a technical workshop in mid-August](#). Neither carries a go-live date, a coverage figure or a data-source list.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

A paper process is being scoped out of existence. The partnership commission and the e-government department [are specifying a web-based auctions platform carrying electronic bid submission, automated ranking, bidder anonymity and digital publication of results](#), with requirements gathered at Blantyre under a World Bank-funded project. No cost, go-live date or auction volume is stated.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

The spending dashboard is running and its address is not on the record. The ministry [stated the real-time constituency development fund dashboard's coverage and its complaints channel](#), at the same event that disclosed councils receiving clean audit opinions falling to 18 in 2024/25 from 22 the year before. No address for the dashboard is established in anything the base holds, so a transparency instrument published against a falling audit record cannot itself be inspected.

Capacity

Training and skills

An operator's school programme reports [36 schools connected with a further nine scheduled in 2026, laboratories equipped with smart televisions and tablets, 12 local e-learning sites zero-rated, and more than 32,000 learners and over 900 teachers benefiting directly](#). All the figures are the company's own; the [continental partnership behind it is worth US\\$57m and targets 5,000 schools across 13 countries by 2027](#). The same foundation's scholarship arm named its [first 25 beneficiaries on 18 August, drawn from 17 districts and taking eight programmes at the science and technology university, computer systems and cyber security among them](#) — the places announced at the January launch, filled seven months later. No continuation beyond the one cohort is stated.

Inclusion

Access to services

The first usable figure for how many Malawians are online came from the operators' own trade association rather than from the state. Its report [puts 80% of the population offline despite 87% 4G population coverage, and estimates MWK 1.1 trillion of economic value and 490,000 jobs by 2030 from closing the usage gap](#), setting out six policy priorities for the government and the regulator. The gap it identifies is usage and not coverage, which is a finding the base had no measurement for; the value estimate is modelled by an interested party, and among the six asks is cutting the mobile-service taxes its members pay. Against it stands [a presidential target of 80% internet usage by 2026](#) that has never had a published baseline.

Digital divides

The universal service fund is in operation and funded from the regulator's annual budget allocation, and its [director general stated existing funding levels remain insufficient to meet the country's connectivity needs](#). A school connectivity project runs under it and the secondary-school skills work above is stated to draw on it. No income, balance or disbursement figure is held for any year, and the base holds no regulator annual report or fund account at all.

Data

National statistics

The statistical office and the communications regulator [put a Fourth National ICT Survey into the field from August to October across all districts, including the refugee camp at Dzaleka](#), covering mobile and computer ownership, internet access, digital financial services, e-commerce and cybersecurity awareness. No publication date for the results is stated, which is the part that decides whether it informs anything.

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